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AFP NEW JERSEY | 60-MINUTE WEBINAR

Unlocking the Middle

How to Build a High-Performing Mid-Level Donor Program



Anthony R. Alonso
President & CEO, Catapult Fundraising

Growing your donor base at every stage of the giving journey.

About your presenter



Anthony R. Alonso
President & CEO

- **35+ years in direct fundraising and donor engagement**
  Mid-level, legacy, annual, and capital campaign programs nationwide
- **Past President, AFP Las Vegas, Past Board Member of AFP NJ and Global.**
  AFP NJ Consulting Excellence Award Recipient, AFP Las Vegas Outstanding Fundraising Professional Award Recipient.
- **Programs across many campaigns**
  Education, public media, social services, arts, and faith-based organizations

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“Donor loyalty is not about the donor being loyal to you. It is about you being loyal to the donor.”

Anthony R. Alonso



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What we will cover today

1

Trends

Why the middle matters more than ever

2

Segment

Who belongs in your mid-level pool

3

Model

Engagement Officers and an 8-stage journey

4

Steward

Individual asks and a real cadence

5

Pipeline

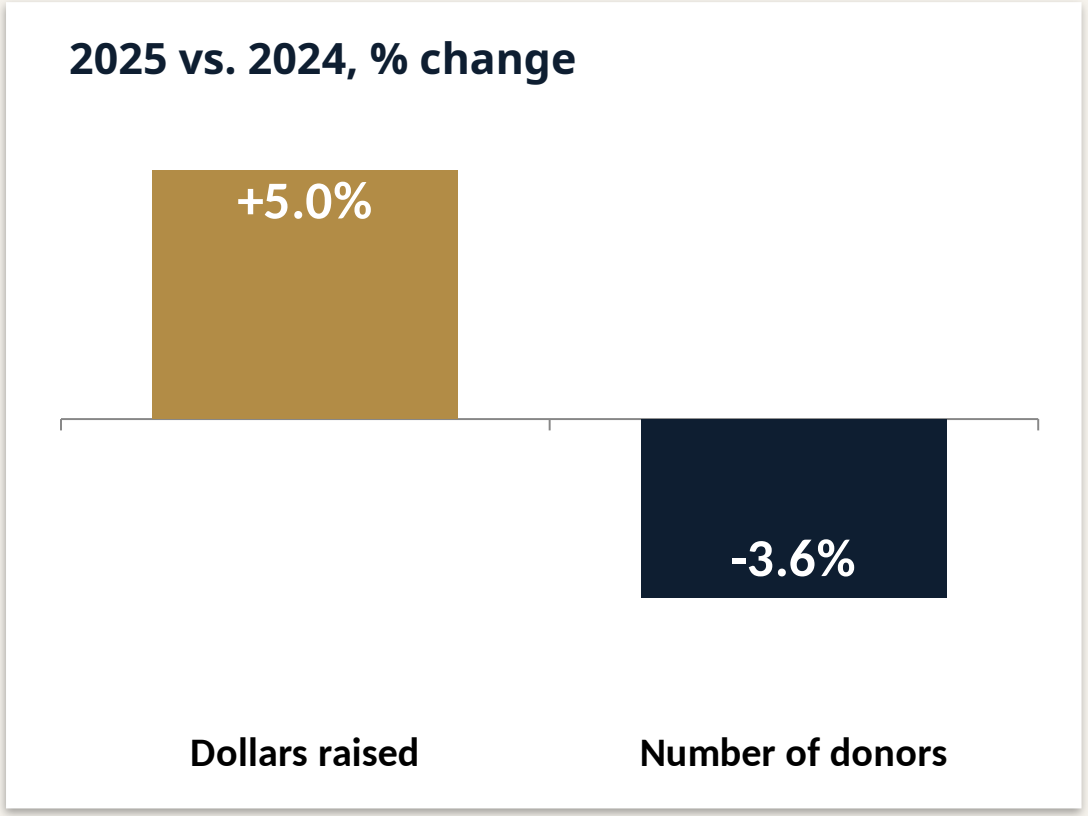
Spotting and moving major gift prospects

Bring your questions. We will save time at the end for discussion.

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Fewer donors are giving more

Total dollars are growing while donor counts keep shrinking.



$617.2B

Total U.S. giving in 2025, up 5.7%

64%

From individuals ($394.2B)

−3.6%

Change in donor count, 5th straight decline

43.3%

Overall donor retention

Sources: Giving USA 2026 (year 2025); Fundraising Effectiveness Project Q4 2025 Report.

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The most overlooked part of the pyramid



Major gifts

Assigned to a gift officer. Personal, strategic, measured.

Mid-level donors

Too valuable for a form letter, rarely in a portfolio.

Annual fund

Mail, email, and events at scale.

The gap: loyal donors with real capacity, and no one assigned to them.

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Why mid-level donors fall through the cracks



No owner

Too many for a major gift portfolio, so no one is accountable.

Mass treatment

They get the same appeal as a $25 donor, and they notice.

Inconsistent touch

Stewardship happens when there is time, which means rarely.

Missed signals

DAF gifts, stock gifts, and capacity clues go unnoticed.

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Defining your mid-level pool

Set the band for your organization, then layer in behavior and capacity.

Giving history

Cumulative and largest gift in a defined band. Common ranges run $1,000 to $10,000; smaller shops often start at $250 to $500.

Behavioral indicators

Recency, frequency, years of loyalty, multi-year giving, event attendance, volunteering, and response to past asks.

Capacity data

Wealth screening on select prospects shows who is giving far below what they could. Treat capacity as potential, not expectation.

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Segmenting the pool into action groups

Upgrade-ready	**High capacity, consistent giving** Priority asks and first in line for major gift review.
Loyal core	**Steady multi-year donors** Retention first. Steward deeply, ask thoughtfully.
At risk	**Lapsing or slipping** Reconnect with a thank-you before any ask.

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The Engagement Officer Model

Treat every qualifying donor like a portfolio assignment.

- ✓ **One officer, all year**
  The same person builds the relationship, so it compounds.
- ✓ **A real portfolio**
  Roughly 300 to 500 donors per officer.
- ✓ **Feels like your organization**
  Branded email and handwritten notes. Technology supports; people talk.



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Three ways donors experience you

	Annual fund	Engagement Officer	Major gift officer
Relationship owner	None	**One officer, all year**	One officer
Portfolio size	Thousands	**~300 to 500**	Small, focused
Primary channel	Mail and email	**Phone, email, mail, notes**	In person
Ask	Same for all	**Individualized**	Individualized
Stewardship	Receipts, newsletter	**Planned cadence**	Custom plan

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The 8-stage mid-level engagement journey



1	**Identify**	Screen giving history and capacity
2	**Research**	Profile priority donors
3	**Thank**	A call with no ask
4	**Discover**	Learn why they give
5	**Ask**	An individualized request
6	**Fulfill**	Confirm, remind, thank
7	**Steward**	A planned yearly cadence
8	**Advance**	Hand off major gift prospects

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First conversation: thanks before the ask



OPEN WITH THANKS

Acknowledge how long they have given and what their support has made possible.

THEN LISTEN

Why did you first give? What matters most to you? How do you like to hear from us?

WHAT YOU LEARN

Interests and passions that shape the future ask.

Preferred channels and timing.

Life events and giving vehicles such as a DAF or IRA.

THE GOAL

They hang up feeling good about you.

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Individualized ask strategies

Upgrade

Anchored to their history, tied to the impact they told you they care about.

Installments

Ask for half the annual target four times a year. Completed, it doubles annual giving.

Renew

For at-risk donors, the ask is simply to stay with you.

Frame it: "You have… You understand… Would you consider…"

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A multi-channel stewardship cadence

Choose up to seven touches a year, across channels, with no ask in most of them.



Mix the channels, sign every note, and let most touches carry no ask.

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Finding hidden major gift prospects

Your Engagement Officers hear signals your database cannot see.

Pays in full, early

Pledges paid at once often signal more capacity.

Giving vehicles

Gifts from a DAF, IRA, stock, or family foundation.

Capacity gap

Screening shows ability far above current giving.

Deep engagement

Volunteers, event regulars, and long loyalty.

Life events

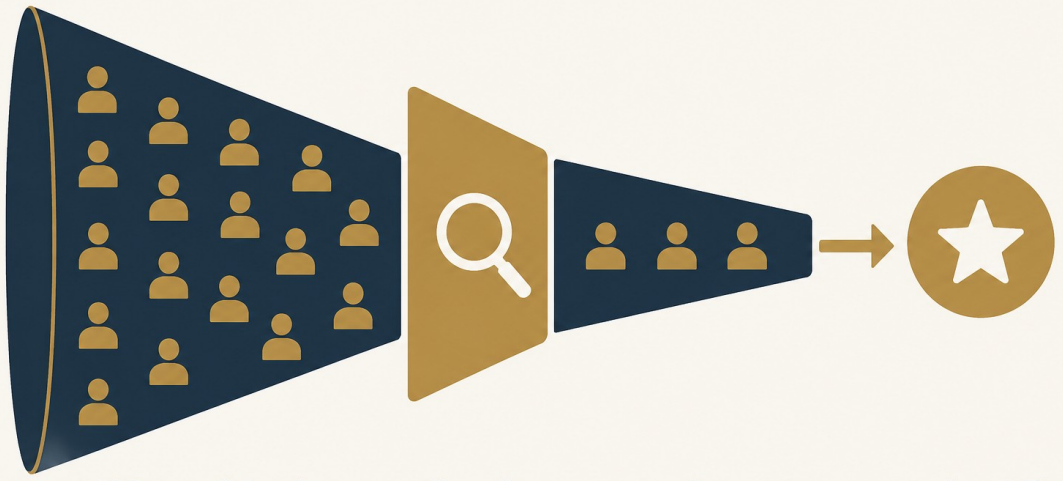
Retirement, a business sale, an inheritance.

They ask questions

Interest in naming, endowment, or planned gifts.

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A clear pathway into the major gift portfolio



1. Flag

Log the signal in the CRM the same day.

2. Research

Build a full profile: capacity and affinity.

3. Review

Decide together: advance or keep stewarding.

4. Handoff

A personal introduction. No cold call.

Agree on the criteria in advance so handoffs are routine, not a turf question.

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What results can look like

Education, public media, social services, arts, and faith-based programs.



39%

Average increase in mid-level giving in year one

2x

Some programs doubled mid-level giving

200%+

Increase in average gift at one faith-based foundation

Source: Catapult Fundraising program results. Results vary by organization and donor file.

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How to measure your program

Retention

Mid-level renewal rate vs. your file overall.

Upgrade rate

Share of donors who increased their gift.

Average gift

Year-over-year change for the pool.

Touches completed

Did each donor get the planned cadence?

Handoffs

Prospects advanced to major gifts.

Pipeline value

Gifts closed from handed-off donors.

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Getting started: your first 90 days

30

Define

Pull the file, set your band, segment into action groups.

60

Assign

Name an owner, build portfolios, map the cadence.

90

Engage

Start thank-you calls, track signals, report monthly.

Start small if you must. One owner and 100 donors beats a perfect plan that never launches.

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Questions & discussion



Anthony R. Alonso, President & CEO
AnthonyA@catapultfr.com | catapultfr.com

Thank you, AFP New Jersey.